SPREADING CHEER

The government's welfare schemes have achieved remarkable success in providing essential services nationwide



HINDUSTAN TIMES

A ROBUST PRINCIPLE BEHIND THE MODI GOVERNMENT'S WELFARE SCHEMES is *antyodaya* (no one is left behind). The programmes to ensure drinking water from taps, cooking gas connection, housing for all and health coverage have done just that.

The proof is in the numbers and geography of coverage. For example, the flagship PM Awas Yojana has already constructed over 30 million houses; the Swachh Bharat scheme has built 117.2 million toilets; the Har Ghar Nal Se Jal Yojana has seen 146.7 million households with tap water, and 96 million gas connections have been provided under the PM Ujjwala Yojana.

"One scheme that stands out the most for me in terms of its impact on our welfare is Ayushman Bharat," says healthcare expert and NITI Aayog member Dr V.K. Paul. Data shows that in the past 10 years, 60 million treatments worth Rs 77,298 crore have been provided. The government estimates that this has saved the country a whopping Rs 1.25 lakh crore in out-of-pocket expenditure. This has been further helped by Jan Aushadhi outlets, which provide affordable medicines—there are over 10,000 outlets now. Experts say several significant achievements have been possible after Covid-19. "It was an unforeseen crisis, but the measure of success was our vaccination programme where we delivered 2.2 billion made-in-India vaccines," says Dr Paul. Other key gains of that time, much of which continue to play a role in healthcare infrastructure now, include the increase in ICU beds from 2,168 to 144,000, oxygen-supported beds from 50,583 to 514,000, and sanctioning of 1,500 PSA (medical-grade oxygen) plants.

The government has also invested in human resources for healthcare. If one adds Ayush doctors, the doctor-patient ratio is 1:834. "We have manpower policies for nursing, skilling, education, pharma and dental, which will show its impact on the ecosystem in the years to come," says Dr Paul. A total of 57,592 MBBS seats and 39,489 PG seats have been added to medical institutions since 2014, and 15 new AIIMS and 225 other new medical colleges have been set up.

Digital healthcare remains a crucial part of the government's focus—150 million teleconsultations have been done through Ayushman Aarogya Mandirs. The government has set up 164,000 such centres where comprehensive primary healthcare is provided by strengthening sub health centres and primary health centres.

Many say the real success has been the foundation laid for primary healthcare. "When you invest in health, you must focus on all aspects, including the ground-level basics," says Dr Randeep Guleria, former director, AIIMS, Delhi. As a result, the sex ratio is 1,020 women per 1,000 men for the first time, and the maternal mortality rate declined to 97 per lakh live births in 2018-20 from 130 in 2014-16. Experts credit this to the 39.4 million free antenatal check-ups and the training of ASHA and Anganwadi workers to provide maternal and child care, as well as spread awareness on the benefits of having girls. It is through the close to 1 million ASHA and 1.3 million Anganwadi workers that the healthcare measures have aligned with the government's welfare goal—that no one is left behind. ■

-Sonali Acharjee

75% of villages are **open defecation-free**	**96 MN cooking gas connections** provided under PM Ujjwala Yojana	**30 MN houses** built under PM Awas Yojana	**76%** households have **tap water** supply under Har Ghar Nal Se Jal Yojana
60 MN hospital admissions under Ayushman Bharat	**10,000 Jan Aushadhi** outlets are operational	**2.2 BN Made-in-India vaccines** given during Covid	**>97,000 seats** have been added to medical institutions